

THE ART OF THE DRY FLY

2.5-Hour Foundations Clinic · Student Handout · Condensed from the Full Program

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2.5 hrs

8:00 AM–10:30 AM

~1.5 hrs

ON-WATER TIME

5

SESSIONS

4

SKILL PILLARS COVERED

Presentation Casting · Active & Passive Floats · Rise Forms · Fly Selection

Resources: [Leader Construction](#) · [Fly Casting Terms & Definitions](#) · [Fly Fishing Terms & Definitions](#)

QUICK REFERENCE — RISE FORMS AT A GLANCE

RISE	WHAT IT MEANS / HOW TO RESPOND
Sip	Gentle ring, nose through film — dun or spinner. Dead drift essential.
Slash	Aggressive take — caddis escaping. React quickly; skitter or twitch.
Porpoise Roll	Dorsal-then-tail, no nose — emerger subsurface. Try cripple or soft-hackle.
Boil / Bulge	Hump with no surface break — nymph. Not a dry fly moment.
Spotted Ring	Circular ring with bubbles — spinner in film. Match film pattern.
Compound Rise	Fish drifts under fly and inspects — fix drift before changing fly.

FLOAT STYLES

STYLE	EXECUTION & USE
Dead Drift	Fly leads all line — no drag. Duns, spinners, trapped emergers.
Twitch	1-inch rod-tip hammer. Caddis and stonefly trigger.
Skitter	3–4 fast rod pulses cross-current. Caddis behavior.
Skate	Sustained rod-high movement. Pool tails and smooth slicks. No V-wake.

FLY STYLE BY WATER TYPE

WATER TYPE	RECOMMENDED STYLE & PATTERNS
Pocket Water & Riffles	High-floating attractors: Royal Wulff, Stimulator, Humpy, Elk Hair Caddis
Run Seams	Convertible: Parachute Adams, Klinkhåmer, Convertible Caddis
Glassy Flats & Pools	Precise imitations: CDC Dun, Sparkle Dun, Comparadun, Griffith's Gnat
Pool Tails	Low-riding emergers & cripples: CDC Emerger, RS2, Barr Emerger

REFUSAL RESPONSE — FIX DRIFT BEFORE CHANGING FLY

#	ACTION	WHY
1	Adjust Drift	Lengthen tippet, change angle, add aerial mend

2	Extend Tippet	12–18" of finer tippet — more S-curve, less shadow
3	Downsize Fly	Drop one or two hook sizes
4	Change Stage	Emerger → dun → spinner or vice versa
5	Change Pattern	Last resort — stage, size, and drift must be right first

2.5-Hour Foundations Clinic

8:00 – 8:15 am

Welcome, observation philosophy & leader check

PHILOSOPHY + GEAR

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Understand the instructor approach: observation before presentation
- Inspect rod, leader, and tippet setup for dry fly readiness
- Match tippet size to fly size before the first cast

KEY CONCEPTS

4X–7X tippet for flies #10–#22 · Nylon monofilament only for dry flies — never fluorocarbon · Diameter and stiffness control turnover, not breaking strength

ACTIVITIES

- Brief intro: observation before presentation
- Leader and tippet check — instructor verifies each student's setup
- Quick turnover test on flat water

Checkpoint: Each student's leader demonstrates controlled turnover before advancing to the stream.

8:15 – 8:25 am · Walk to water

8:25 – 9:15 am

Presentation casting — reach, pile & curve casts

CASTING

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Execute reach cast, pile cast, and at least one curve cast
- Understand why aerial mends outperform post-landing mends for dry flies

KEY CONCEPTS

Reach cast: rod tip swings upstream during forward cast · Pile/puddle cast: controlled collapse for instant slack · Curve cast: banking around obstacles · Upstream vs. downstream cast geometry

ACTIVITIES

- Flat-water drill: reach, pile, curve left, curve right
- Moving-water seam drill: which cast solves this current situation?

Checkpoint: Each student completes a reach cast across a seam and a pile cast to a pool. Instructor assesses whether tippet leads or lags the fly.

9:15 – 9:55 am

Active vs. passive floats & rise form reading

FLOAT + RISE

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Distinguish when a dead drift serves vs. when movement triggers strikes
- Execute a twitch and skitter without creating a V-wake
- Identify sip, slash, and porpoise roll rises from the bank

KEY CONCEPTS

Dead drift: fly leads all line — no drag · Twitch: 1-inch rod-tip hammer for caddis and stonefly · Skitter: 3–4 fast pulses cross-current · V-wake: the drag signature that kills a presentation

ACTIVITIES

- Calm eddy: twitch and skitter drill — partner enforces no V-wake rule
- Bankside observation: short watch-only exercise — students call rise type

Checkpoint: Each student correctly identifies passive or active float for one water type and calls at least 2 rise forms from live observation.

9:55 – 10:20 am

Fly selection by water type & the first cast

FLY + APPROACH

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Match fly style to water type using the attractor-to-imitation spectrum
- Approach a rising fish without detection
- Execute the sequence: observe → position → select → cast

KEY CONCEPTS

Pocket water: attractor · Seams: convertible · Flat pools: precise imitation · Approach from below and to the side — never upstream of a sighted fish · First cast is the best cast — plan it, don't rush it

ACTIVITIES

- Fly box sort: organize by water type, not hatch
- One full presentation attempt on a rising fish, with coaching

Checkpoint: Each student completes one full presentation sequence on a rising fish. Instructor grades stealth, fly selection logic, and cast execution.

10:20 – 10:30 am

Final debrief & written feedback

REVIEW

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Receive individual written feedback
- Identify one priority to build on

ACTIVITIES

- Written instructor assessment returned to each student
- One strength and one priority — verbal

Checkpoint: Each student leaves with one written strength and one named priority for the next time on the water.